

NOTES ON THE «TENCH» NOVEL

Novel of an Earth colony on a faroff planet, and the decline and decay both socially, economically, and psychologically of them all: ala Paul Bowles & «The Beckoning Fair One,» & THE CASTLE -- ending ala NICHTS NEUES IN WESTEN: the last death. A study of advancing entropy ala «Silent Snow.» Each of them decays differently.

Alcoholism ala Mike & Annie.

Solitude, withdrawal. Schizy -- like me.

Woman who runs away ala D.H. Lawrences & «The Fox» and Frost's poem about the young wife.

Through all decay. The book focusses on one particular handful. The «officers»? No interest in the physios -- the laborers, who go native ala ROBINSON CRUSO.

Every possible response to life is tried, and all fail (were they selected on the basis of this difference? A test to see which life-style has greatest survival value). Maybe the shrink alone knows this -- even the «captain» doesn't .

The Great Tench, like THE CASTLE, could help. (Or so some of them believe.) But efforts to get through to it fail -- as with the printer's products, its advice seems garbled. (Nonsensical? Like fortune cookies?) The same story line over and over again, each time with a dif. type of person, each of whom applies his own idiomatic solution -- some fail right away -- some much later. But at last the final one dies. But there are «physio» companions for each officer. But this rules out any social interaction between the protagonists, which would remove all bickering & bitching as their nerves fray.

BEST: if all z.b. 5 of them are there together, but captainship rotates, as in SOLAR LOTTERY» -- bottletwitch. Or are they one poly-encephalic organism ala the Damon Knight story?

They were to receive their orders after they got to the settlement. But when they put the tape on, it's ruined, and there's no radio contact (why? Proximity to star?) They fire off a rocket to their staging area-base, but months (years?) will pass before a reaction reaches them. So they have no orders -- nothing to do except what they feel like doing -- or think should be done.

Of course it occurs to them that the garbled tape was no accident. They are an experiment, guinea pigs. But they can't be sure of this!

Each character arrived on his own ship. Prior to start of book they don't know one another. Like AND THEN THERE WERE NONE (do they actually die off, one by one? YES. (Again like NICHTS NEUES.)

Need of good characters as in SHIP OF FOOLS. Better than in EYE IN THE SKY.

The «realization» that they're an experiment comes gradually & too late. It is their final realization, and robs /some of/ them of their last remaining store of esprit. (They have «proof» of this: they discover monitoring devices which record all they do & say,

As the last one dies he sees a rocket arriving with help. They were not an experiment; it was an accidental SNAFU, without meaning or purposes. (Maybe the rocket has a medical robot, which saves him -- as in end of LORD OF THE FLIES. Robot gives him choice: does he want to live or go on & die?

At first they are able to function as a family, with one relation-

ship like Joe & Lou on «Mannix.» The «small store» syndrome -- they would structure out a pecking order, election of one of their # as boss.

Sam Morley. Protag boss.

Ben Tallchief («Joe»).

(1) Mysticism introverted teenager (Neil, Wilder Bentley, Al Ild, Chris; artist & photographer.

(2) Introverted older organizer-boss, thinker (Avram) lazy. 40ish. Anthropologist.

(3) Extraverted 30ish technician, manual skills (Lindy).

(4) Habit-oriented sychophant girl -- like debrained ant. Verbal skills. Alcoholic. (Annie, Thelma, Maxime, Lynn Sigh. In 30s).

(5) Iron-willed old lady (Grandma Hackett), sociologist (Dr. Jambor), nags -- selfish. Conservative. Cultured, but not prude like Mrs. Pritchett. Nobility of intellect. In 70s. Famous sociologist.

(6) Extraverted doer of deeds (Bill Cook). Cardiac type, rough, no humor, in 50s. Engineer.

(7) (Frank Willis) Electronics (Boody) Psychopathic rages and moods of sensitivity.

(8) (Halevy) Psychologist.

(9) (Jan Forgue). Linguist.

SKILL:

DIRECTION OF FAILURE.

- | | |
|-----------------------------|------------------------------|
| 2. Anthropologist. | Hebephrenia. Gluttony. |
| 3. Manual skills. | Depression & withdrawal. |
| 4. Records & Filing office. | Bureaucrat. Booze. Masocism. |
| 5. Sociologist | Inability to adapt. |
| 6. Engineer. | Overwork. Cardiac. |

7. Electronics & computer programmer. Murder. Rage.

8. Psychologist. Twisted & evil -- ~~xxx~~ sadism.

9. Linguist. Suicide. Love.

1. Artist & photographer. Mysticism, native.

10. Doctor. Venality, drugs, corruption (Beaton).

-- No marine biologist?

Ignatz Melchior. Carol Walsh. Claude Thugg. 11. Boody.

Violence. Lon. Moody.

4. has slept with each of the men. She is pretty.

Their instructions: signal from satellite in orbit -- it fails to release signal when they press the button. Since the satellite was necessary for them to radio out, they are therefore unable to radio anywhere; all they can do is fire off emergency rockets.

At end, when help arrives, protag at once asks, «What was our mission?» And then, «Who is in charge?» («You.»)

Music library of tapes. Verity of their situation: always on everywhere.

Any way to tie in older ideas, z.b. when humans worship superior race, like dogs in «Invest. of a Dog.»

Nosers. Ships, that can only go one way. Called «Chevrolet,» «Ford,» etc.

Widsom Book of the Lost ~~xxx~~ (etc.) Of Earth.

«Fixed ecology base» -- in which participants are ordered not to meddle & change things. Compare «Organization of Reconstruction and Environmental Stability.» Comes later, if at all. Requires act of congress? ORES.

Susie Smart. Called Susie Dumb. The girl «friday.» But like

Janet. (Carol Walsh)

NAMES:

Sam Morley (2) AVRAM ~~Amkhrmpmings~~ Anthropologist

Ben Tallchief (3) LINDY Manual skills of pioneering, or survival type. «Make do.» And amateur naturalist.

Susie Smart (4) ANNIE Clerk-typist.

Roberta Rockingham (5) GRANDMA Sociologist.

Fred Gossim (6) BILL COOK Engineer.

Jack Nielson (7) FRANK WILLIS Electronics & computers.

Wade Frazer (8) HALEVY Psychologist

Betty Jo Berm (9) JAN FORGUE linguist

Tony Dunkelwelt (1) WILDER BENTLEY, Cris. Photographer, teenager.

Dr. Milton Babble (10) ~~EMMM~~ BEATON Md.

Ignatz Thugg (11) BOODY Thermoplastics, like Pete. And is printer programming expert. But when the printer puddles things, Thugg simply shamesh them. Ben tries to make them function, along with Jack Nielson & Fred Gossim.

Maggie Walsh (12) CAROL Theology? Yes.

Bert Kosler (13) Very old & frail. Senile? Custodian? Yes.

For them all to die but Ben, someone must be killing them, as in AND THEN THERE WERE NONE. Hebephrenia, z.b. doesn't kill, & at end only Ben is left (he got (8)).

Motive for killing: when they «weren't of use» any more.

Punishment for their «evil.»

Or: down to 2, Ben & creep. Ben knows he didn't do it, so creep must have. Fight -- creep runs, hides. Ben finds him dead -- murdered.

None of them were doing it. The Great Tench did it -- obligingly -- when they «wore out» (and wanted on some level to die?).

Could their mission have been for the purpose of educating the Tench as to human values -- & their failure to do this cost them their lives.

Opening. Ben Tallchief lands. Finds Suzie Dumb and Sam Morley; she is drinking & crying & he is eating various cheeses.

There are robys there, robots who have built and who maintain the new base. Like ants; then can't change anything about it. Ant-like. Just repair molecule for molecule (printer? A non-T. Life form of great use. Robys could be using it. Tench could kill it when it puddles.

Better to have several tench, otherwise too much like LORD OF THE FLIES. And this can bring in «dogs to man, man to tench» theme.

Or: They avoid the tenches -- at end, Ben learns that they were ~~supposed~~ supposed to seek out the tenches as much as possible. Except for Tony they never really paid any attention to the tenches, & Tony was trying to die. To merge with the landscape (like «The Young Wife. /Maybe change him to young woman?

Or: yes, have Tony young like Chris, & goes with Maggie Walsh -- it is beautiful, not at all like Lord of the Flies. A Tender love affair between a 30 year old woman & a 17 year old boy. And then they find her dead -- merged with tree & rock & stone. She sat for hours -- they find her sitting.

Best bet would be all 3: Maggie, Tony, and ancient frail old man, all die. Bert Kosler.

The violent streak which destroys each person should be intro-

duced in a ~~purely~~ purely benign form, as if based on the therum that a vice is a virtue carried to an extreme -- it is as if each person is allowed to become himself to an ultimate degree. Interpersonal action dwindles and the persons withdraw into each's private world, which could be shown by an increasing variety of subjectivities -- whereas in the beginning the subjectivities were so similar as to seem shared and hence objective, which is what they were -- and cease to be. So the «journey» of the book is into the deeper unconsciousness.

There is no stream of consciousness in the beginning. But something like it -- but not it -- occurs with growing power as the book progresses. But each person's Eigenwelt must be coherently put forth. Difference, not «stream of consciousness,» takes place. The worlds become more unlike -- in essence, unique. Communication breaks down with growing depth, when shown as interior 3rd person v-p it is intelligible (to the reader) but when the others speak to the 3rd person v-p character, he can't understand them.

Some native (alien) entity on the planet is causing them to enter the deeper & deeper levels of each's own subjective mind. Or it could be a «force field» or something native which they use (even eat). So more radical autism is possible.

They leave the dome & explore the planet. Each finds it a different world, without realizing that each of their vies of it differs. After all, there has to be something which their autistic views is about.

Maybe at * last their views of the dome begin to vary, & and the significance of this is not lost on them. The dome & everything in it becomes «alien.» But not «barbaric» (in other words they do not

devolve -- until, for example, they can't work the gadgets of the dome. But each could put them to idiosyncratic & unique uses).

Maybe tench & other entity are known by Zoroastrian titles -- or rather such titles are applied to them. Anyhow a dualistic world.

Not Zoroastrian but Manichee -- infused elements of christianity. (But not christian names.) Z.B. The walker-on-earth. The saving judge (or judge-of-mercy). He-who-has-sinned. And the Manufacturer (like the printers? And the cruel Eater-of-life. The Lover-of-decay.

The planet is called Delmar.

Each person's view of the planet is heavy with aspects & manifestations of his valent idea, but (1) it is not wish-fulfillment (z.b. not fountains of booze for the lush) & (2) we discover what the valent idea is by working back from the worldviews, but maybe this is bad & only «you are as you desire me.» Play down the explanation of origin of each slant. But the deities appear in each world, and the same -- so the only communicable aspect is --oddly-- the theological aspect.

The brewery -- hospital -- hotel -- prison -- restaurant.

Differs from EYE in that it is not a brewery but he decides it is -- forms a weltview idea in which it's that. But nobody else sees it as a brewery -- like the whorehouse-hospital scene in the movie FREUD. On the other hand, unlike FREUD, there is no actual thing which ~~ham~~ it «really» is, as in a Kafka novel it's never resolved...or: the multiplicity of conflicting views is finally resolved when the theological aspect is revealed by the deities. It is Walhalla (etc. A temple. Home of the gods.) So there is a real, platonistic ideal template reality beneath every appearance. Frivilin. Frivernlin. Friverlin.

Odd possible note. Since they die during the novel, they, each of them, might see Frivelin properly after death. So a part of the novel deals with the experiences of dead people. But one might see it properly before death -- a deteriorated hebephrenic with delusions. And when he dies, the only difference in his view is that he now sees the others again (like Bergman's SEVENTH SEAL.) Or: he doesn't die, but is only one rescued. Or: he isn't on planet or part of the group; he is in medical cell aboard ship on its way to Delmar; he is v-p character, and the only one not part of the group. He could be on ship & still die on Delmar, when they let him out of ship. Or: he could, when arriving at Delmar, (1) See all the now dead group (whom he previously never met nor knew anything about) -- lives, and besides them, (2) sees Frivelin as it actually is. By this means we learn what it actually is. But he is only there briefly, and then he is carted back to the ship, which takes off. (And he has seen the gods, too.)

Better if, as soon as first one dies, we pick up v-p & see Frivelin as it is. But deader can't go back & tell the others, as hebe does to members of his ship. Ship's captain feeds hebe's statements to computer which has previously analyzed his statements as psychotic. Now it says he's right (they also feed all data in colony's info banks to computer). The captain says, «We'll have to report this because of the rule barring colonization or investation of one of the planets on which gods reside.» His calm at discovering this is blow to reader who expects captain to freak out at the news. (It's general secret, known only to Establishment higher-ups, of which he is one.)

Earth has made compact with gods to leave their world alone.

(Gods are no longer on Earth, but once were.) (But all gods wherever they are receive prayers from all worshippers. Maybe sometimes --but rarely-- return to intervene on planets they've left (left when classified as homeostatic, i.e. self-perpetuating.)

When asked who --or what-- he is, a god shows flat pack of official type i.d. Since these are earthmen.

Pinal gland in each person acts as transmitter of prayers to the gods (defined as self-creating ultra-homeostatic quasi-organic polyencephalic organisms possessing absolute knowledge, unlimited power and objective --i.e. non subjective-- capacity for judgment-basing). If any god wishes to act on prayer it is his business. But the Walker-on-earth (Or Walker-in-daytime?) often shows up to alleviate suffering unasked -- unlike the Manufacturer, etc. Or: the Walker-on-earth always is present, watching, but does not act. The One-who-has-sinned (not Christ but Judas $\frac{3}{4}$) replaces suffering humans with himself. Christ rescues, instead. The Manufacturer alters the situation retroactively -- each has his own way of approaching problem of those «trying to die.» (No death comes unwanted. By dying a person ransoms himself back to purity from original sin; his death cancels the sin.) (The death urge --thanos-- is the desire to make the ultimate sacrifice in repayment of the Debt, which, each person knows, must come sooner or later) (knows on nonconscious level) (animals pray, too, to The Mother-of-us-all, a sort of nourishing shewolf -- they go to suck at her teats, and are freed) (the curse is on nature, too).

The hebe is precog, and lives in «fantasy world» which is really Delmar on which he soon will be. Then, after they leave, he precogs experience on Earth, which he has never seen. Earth is huge sanitarium

for those who freak out in space; this is because of losing the primordial tie (to Earth). Many go back. Millions. And Earth society is artificially kept at 1968 level -- before first man left Earth & landed on another world. The poor psychotics are told «This is as far as we've yet gotten,» and the first space flight is postponed indefinitely.

Psychotics are called «ostriches,» for obvious reasons. Earth is called «The aviary» and its fake culture is «the sand pile,» which also suggest abreaction to childhood.

Delmak-O, not Delmar.

Base on Delmak-O was illegal, because of gods. That was why their employers went about briefing them so oddly -- got scared at the last & pulled out, leaving the unenlightened colony there.

The Maker-of-decay. The manufacturer built all; the Maker-of-Decay declines it. Of the good gods, the only one whom the M-of-D can affect is the Manufacturer; this is why the Walker-On-~~XXX~~ Earth-in-daylight came into being. The decay can't be reversed, but the original curse which the Manufacturer put on it --which came because of the appearance of the M-of-D-- is lifted by death. And the two other gods locally help, prior to death: through them the ultimate sacrifice is allowed to be postponed, on the grounds that at this time it is asking too much. The real desire to die has not arrived yet. Prayer is the expression of the unwillingness to make the ultimate sacrifice. The one who pays is asking for the forward-motion machinery (of the Manufacturer) to ~~nm~~ halt. Maybe the Manufacturer never intervenes; it is always the 3 others.

The Maker-of-Rocks-and-Gas or -Grass? Or, the Maker-of-Rocks. The M-of-Grass. Or the Maker-of-Rocks-and-~~nm~~ Glass? Or M-of-Glass? A universe spunt of of molten glass? Forms? All shapes?

The Dooer-of-Decay. Decay is retrogression of form -- hence the unformer or Uniform-Dooer. The Entropy-Dooer, -Maker, -One. Each category has a name; hence: the Unnamer, the Undoer-of-Names, the Dooer-of-Unnames, «Puddled.» Hence the Puddler. The Dooer- or Maker-of Puddles.

The Manufacturer keeps time forward generally, unmakes when needed -- dismantles, which is not what the Undoer-of-Names does. Decay still moves forward in time; to halt decay one (e.g. the Manufacturer) would --could-- halt time. But decay is «out of time.»

The decay of plants is not a step in the creation of new plants but a process which is undone by /seeded/ new plants. If there were no decay, no new plants would be needed. Creation must be reattempted every day -- and often fails (as witness the extinction of species. The evolution of life forms is an attempt to foil decay by offering improved or rather new forms, which may be more resistant to decay. Creation each day does not have to repeat itself -- since it occurs in forward time it can be always different. This is one of its characteristics: new «names» are brought forth daily, while old ones are preserved, if possible.

Decay does not occur in time but instantly, striking like death.

They do not see the bldg as they wish it to be but as they unconsciously expect it to be (hence the prison, the whippery, etc.) Like a Rohrschacht test? And it must be kept in mind that it is difficult --if not impossible-- to what what it is. (A vague sign painted on it: factory...or: brewery...or wakerium.)

The problem of the dualism suggested by the notion that the Form Destroyer is not God and never was (and hence was able to surprise God) can be reasorbed into monism this way.

The Form Destroyer is Absolutely-not-God.

«Absolutely-not-God» is a category of being.

God contains all categories of being.

Therefore God can be Absolutely-not-God, which transcends human reason & logic but is felt intuitively as being correct. Or:

God is absolute good.

Absolute good, by its nature, knows nothing about absolute evil (since inability to know evil is an attribute of absolute good, in the Christian Science sense).

Therefore if there were an absolute evil, God would not know of it until it manifested itself within the framework of God's creation, the universe.

From this would follow:

God's learning about absolute evil from the relative evil of evil events in cosmological history, would infringe on the absolute quality of God's goodness. ^{SINCE TO KNOW OF EVIL IS TO BECOME TO AN EXTENT EVIL} Therefore, soon after creation, God became diminished --or tainted-- by knowledge of evil, and, like man, ~~man~~ fell into the realm of the Curse (which is an expression of that knowledge of evil ~~xxx~~ by what had been purely good). It has taken God thousands of not millions of years to work his way back out of this critical situation, and, as stated before, the appearance of God in the form of the Redeemer is a sign that he has managed to climb back upward sufficiently to reintroduce new good into his creation. God, then, is once again available to man, and vice versa.

A final note regarding the novel. God can become plural, and/or can appear plural any time he wishes, for obvious reasons. Therefore, the existence of many gods in the novel does not diminish the fact that one God exists behind or beyond this multiplicity. Also, in these various forms there can be distinction, a variety of attributes as well as names (which are applied of course by man, not by God). Also, God can manifest himself in various rôles, as for ~~example~~ example the contradictory manifestations reported in the Old Testament (the best example is God-as-he-appeared-to-Job). During that period, the interval of the Curse, God both loved man (as his creation, and in replica of him) and hated him (as something corrupted by the Form Destroyer and hence not in the form God had given him; hence alien). God's reaction to his experience of finding man, his highest creation, evil, has been well-told in the Old Testament and needs no repeating here. Anyhow, ^{as regards} ~~despite~~ these contradictory rôles of God, the underlying reason can be found in this short, vague, theological resumé.

One further point. It is said in this outline, «God existed alone as a creature of absolute good, knowing nothing about evil or the existence of an absolutely evil entity.» In this case, it means nothing to say, «God existed as a creature of absolute good,» because without evil, or knowledge of evil, God could neither be good nor know what «good» was. (This is why, in the Old Testament, ~~ix~~ it is said that Adam and Eve acquired a knowledge of both good and evil -- not merely evil alone. Up until they acquired this knowledge they were as ignorant of good as they were of evil.) What God would be aware of, in himself, would be his existence, felt as neither good or evil, nor in any relationship to good or evil. What he would experience is being, which is merely a jargon-term for reality, for awareness of existence. His creation --the universe-- would not strike him as good but merely as existing. Later, when he encountered manifestations in his creation of evil, he would experience the changes as motion away from reality -- the undermining of forms being a pulling away of the supports of existence. God would then perceive existence --existence of himself and his creation-- as desirable....hence eventually the term «good» would be applied to his creation --because it exists-- and him, because he made it and tries to keep it existing. So it is enough to state that originally God was; it is unnecessary to state that «he was good,» because we know that he created the universe, and this implies all the good --the legitimate, actual good-- there is. No more is needed. So for «good» read «real.» For «evil» read «unreal» or something made «partially unreal.» (That thing at a former time having been «fully real.»)

On the Presence of the Manufacturer.

Generally the «life cycle» is regarded as a clear-enough example of the need for there to be decay and death for new life to appear; the term «cycle» is self-explanatory. However, the preChristians regarded the appearance of new life each year (the new-grown corn, etc.) as a miracle which might not always occur; hence the need for ritual & ceremony. We are positive that no miracle is involved; the old plants sprout seeds; fish evict eggs; man reproduces along with nature as a whole, so that when he dies --when each living creature dies-- the next generation will be there to replace him and them. But in the Vague New Theology we have it this way: the decay & death are unnatural, to start with, they being evidence of the workings of the Form Destroyer whom God had not anticipated. Each year creatures die; the Form Destroyer, as for so long before us, has been successful. But the Manufacturer is active, too, and replaces the dead & dying with new examples...many of which are altered so as to have a greater chance of surviving. God, then, is always fiddling with the universe to make it work better, and the Form Destroyer is always ahead of him, bringing about the decay of reality which prompts the Manufacturer into new activity (originally he believed that, after the sixth day, the universe had been completed; he rested, and then later on, while walking the earth of his creation, discovered the Form Destroyer at work...so, for him, the work would require perpetual new activity on his part. His resentment is well-recorded.)